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HIGH SCHOOL BASKETBALL

GIRLS DIVISION III

Ursuline brings Regina's huge streak to a halt

BOB FORTUNA
Plain Dealer Reporter

St. Patrick's Day is still three days away, but it's safe to say the celebration in Youngstown began Saturday evening.

A few hours earlier, Ursuline High School's Fighting Irish girls basketball team put an end to Regina's four-year hold of the Division III state crown with a 65-52 regional championship victory at Cuyahoga Falls.

The win not only ended three seasons of frustration for the state's No. 7-ranked team, it also sends Ursuline (24-2) to the Final Four for the first time in head coach Sean Durkin's six-year tenure. The loss snapped Regina's (22-3) postseason win streak at 36 games.

"We really thought we'd be able to get

out of here with a win," said Durkin, whose Fighting Irish were eliminated from the regional by Regina the past three seasons. "Unfortunately for us, we dug ourselves quite a hole."

"I thought it was really important that we cut it to five [points] before the half, and our kids felt real good about themselves in the third quarter."

A five-foot jumper by Alyssa Clark with 4:56 remaining the first half put the Royals ahead, 28-16, before Ursuline began chipping away. Layups by Vanessa Dickson and Tyra Grant bookended a Clark free throw, while Grant's follow-up basket closed the first half to cut Ursuline's deficit to 33-28. Grant collected 13 of her 21 points in the second quarter.

State semifinals

Thursday

Plain City Jonathan Alder (25-1) vs. Youngstown Ursuline (24-2), 1
Oak Hill (24-1) vs. Smithville (24-2), 3

Reece Mitchell's soft jumper opened the second half to put Regina ahead, 35-28, but Ursuline answered loud and clear. Behind Courtney Davidson's three 3-pointers, the Fighting Irish ran off 15 unanswered points to grab the lead for good at 43-35 with 2:54 remaining. Mitchell's 15 points led Regina, followed by Monique Godfrey with 10.

Davidson led all scorers with 26 points and couldn't have found her shooting eye at a better time since Grant

picked up her fourth foul with 4:44 left.

"We decided we're just going to play our best defense we have, which is man-to-man, and we're going to go after this team," Durkin said. "Early in the game, the kids were a little excited and they were settling for jumper, jumper, jumper."

"Once we started getting to the hoop and got them into a little bit of foul trouble, we were then really attacking well," Regina, ranked No. 5 in the state, made three of 17 from the field in its disastrous third quarter with seven of its misses coming on putbacks. Ursuline countered with an 8-for-15 effort.

"You're going to run into spots where you can't buy a shot, and we couldn't," Regina coach Pat Diulus said. "We missed a lot of layups, but it's also something Ursuline had a lot to do with."

"We had them down, 22-11 [after the first quarter], and we couldn't put them away. I thought at that particular juncture, if we would have stepped it up, I think maybe we would have won the game going away."

Simone Redd and Mitchell had four fouls each heading into the fourth quarter and Ursuline capitalized. Tiffani Miller's basket from underneath and an eight-footer by Davidson put the Fighting Irish ahead, 51-40, and it was over.

"It feels great," said Davidson, a Michigan State University recruit. "Nothing can compare to this feeling right now, but winning the state championship. So we've got to get down there, get to Columbus and do our thing."

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BOYS DIVISION I

It's no time to wait

Young Bearcats go to regional

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

As far as Jason Thompson is concerned, the future is now for the sophomore-laden Bedford Bearcats.

"Everybody is talking about our future," said Thompson, one of coach Everett Heard's talented 10th-graders. "But we feel that this team is capable of doing it right now. And that's what we tried to show here today."

Saturday afternoon, the Bearcats were more than capable as their young legs and youthful spirit carried them past a veteran Cleveland Heights team, 70-60, in the Division I boys basketball district championship game at Cleveland South.

Bedford, which outscored the Tigers, 13-3, over the final 2:38, will take a 14-9 record into Thursday's 7 p.m. regional-semifinal game at the University of Akron's JAR Arena. Their opponent will be Euclid district champion Collinwood (20-3).

Top-seeded Cleveland Heights, which had won seven district titles at South since 1990, closed its season at 10-4.

"Heights played great," said Thompson, who led the Bearcats with 18 points. "They came back and had the momentum, but we felt we were strong enough."

The Division I state runner-up in 2000, Bedford used a 9-0 second-quarter run in erasing a four-point deficit. The run featured a follow by Thompson, layups by Thompson and senior forward Marlon Leek, and key assists by sophomore forward Donzale Moore and junior point guard Derek Reed.

Holding their own on the boards against the Tigers in transition, the Bearcats pushed a three-point halftime lead to 50-39. The big baskets were a tip-in by Thompson and a steal and a putback by

BEDFORD
CLEVELAND HTS. 70
60
sophomore
guard Brandon
Pitts.

"They gave us a good lesson on fast-breaking and rebounding," said Cleveland Heights veteran coach Jim Cappelletti. "We were fortunate to beat them earlier in the year at our place. You have to fear their speed and quickness. And they're very strong defensively. I think we're quick, I think they're quicker."

Trailing by eight points entering the fourth quarter, Cleveland Heights displayed its savvy and full-court pressure. The Tigers, on the strength of a soft floater down the lane by senior point guard Darren Jones and a layup by senior post Antoine Gray, tied the score at 57 with 2:38 left. Jones finished with a game-high 22 points, including four 3-pointers.

"Earlier in the season, we might not have responded to those types of runs," Thompson said. "But we've grown up a lot."

Appearing to have stronger legs down the stretch, the Bearcats answered with their decisive run. The 13-3 spurt was highlighted by a steal and layup by Thompson, layups by Moore and sophomore guard Charles Osby off Reed assists, and a breakaway slam-dunk by Osby that brought all of the Bedford faithful to their feet.

"When they hit their first couple of shots, we kept our composure and didn't deviate from our game plan," said Heard, who was a mainstay on Cappelletti's first team at Cleveland Heights (1970-71) and later became an assistant coach for the Tigers. "We made them work. I had never beaten coach Cappelletti before, for whom I have nothing but tremendous respect."

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JOHN KUNTZ / THE PLAIN DEALER

Bearcats players Brandon Pitts, left, and Jason Chapman begin to celebrate after Bedford won its district final against Cleveland Heights Saturday at South High School in Cleveland.

SCOREBOARD

GIRLS BASKETBALL

Regional Finals

Division III

Cuyahoga Falls

Youngstown Ursuline

Regina

Youngstown Ursuline

Regina

Youngstown Ursuline

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